

BEYOND THE KINGDOM

Episode #0003

"The Birthday"

Air Date: Wednesday, January 5, 2005

Prod. #BTK-0003

Story Day: Wednesday, January 5, 2005 (6:44 AM - 11:52 PM
EST)

Teleplay by the Beyond the Kingdom Writers' Room
Final Shooting Script

CAST OF CHARACTERS – EPISODE #0003

(ages as of Wednesday, January 5, 2005)

THE DONOHUES: SIMONE DONOHUE (94) · VICTOR DONOHUE (68) · JOAN DONOHUE (66)

THE OLSONS: DR. PETER OLSON (45) · MARTIN OLSON (23) · MALLORY OLSON (19)

THE BULLOCKS: ROBERT BULLOCK (45) · NATASHA DONOHUE BULLOCK (43) · CHIEF ELXA BULLOCK JACKSON (24) · DET. JEREMY JACKSON (24) · MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK (23, today) · GRACE BULLOCK (20)

THE SMILLEYS: ODESSA SMILLEY (84) · LUCIUS SMILLEY (55) · ESTHER SMILLEY (22) · EMMA SMILLEY (2) · VICTORIA SMILLEY (2)

THE CIRCLE: AMOND BAKER (22) · ARIANNA CUMMINGS (22) · HARMONY DIVINE (22)

THE SEVEN: KEISHA "GHOST" LATTIMORE (25) · DOLORES "MAMA DEE" WHITFIELD (53) · ROMAN GAINES (28, by phone)

RECURRING: CELESTE VAUGHN (24) · CAMILLE RHODES (38) · SILAS MERRIWEATHER (57) · MAYOR JOSEPHINE WHITAKER (55) · DEPUTY CHIEF WARREN HUGHES (46) · BERNADETTE SINCLAIR (59) · GLORIA BAKER (48) · WINSTON FAIRLEY (62) · RUBY "NANA RUBY" TOLLIVER (66) · BRIELLE SUTTON (21) · BEATRIX "NANNY BEA" PENNINGTON (43) · THADDEUS CROWE (40)

DAY PLAYERS: BSI GATE OFFICER DANTE HOLLIS · SMILLEY DRIVER · ASSISTANT DA PRESTON · OTIS · PARTY GUESTS · BANDLEADER

MENTIONED, NOT SEEN: Alvin Donohue (Miami; sends a gift) · Jasmine Olson (Washington) · Sebastian Kingsley (London) · the person on the other end of Martin's calls

FADE IN:

TEASER

1 EXT. SWEET AUBURN – AUBURN AVENUE – DAWN

Wednesday, January 5, 2005 – 6:44 AM EST

Atlanta's historic Black main street, before the city wakes: brick storefronts, Ebenezer's steeple against a pink sky, and a streetlight still buzzing.

At the corner of the 400 block stands a grand old six-story HOTEL of red brick and limestone. It's been closed for years and its windows are boarded, but the carved stone over the entrance still reads:

HOTEL DONOHUE – 1936

A black Maybach idles at the curb. Two men stand on the sidewalk in overcoats, looking up at the building.

VICTOR DONOHUE (68). And MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK, who as of midnight is twenty-three.

VICTOR

Twelve years old, the first time
I brought you here.

MARC

You woke me up at five a.m. I
thought somebody died.

VICTOR

You cried the whole ride.

MARC

I was TWELVE.

VICTOR

You'd graduated from high school.
I thought you'd be more mature.

MARC

I was a genius, Granddaddy, not
an adult. There's a difference.
You of all people should know
that. You married a genius and
she still makes you take out the
trash.

Victor almost smiles. He takes a small velvet pouch from his coat.

VICTOR

Every birthday, I bring you here
and tell you something about this
building you didn't know.

MARC

Last year it was the ballroom
ceiling. Hand-painted by a man
from Harlem who got paid in room
and board for six months.

VICTOR

The year before?

MARC

Duke Ellington's room. 412. He
left a cigarette burn on the
windowsill and Great-Grandma
charged him for it.

VICTOR

(nodding, satisfied)

This year I'm not going to tell
you anything.

He opens the pouch and tips it into Marc's palm. An old
brass HOTEL KEY with a heavy fob, stamped: "No. 1."

MARC

(quietly)

Room One.

VICTOR

Your great-grandfather's first
office. Nine by eleven feet. A
desk, a chair, a telephone, and a
window that looked out on this
street.

(beat)

He ran everything from that room
until 1958. The hotels. The bank.
The insurance company. The
movement money. All of it, from
nine by eleven.

Marc turns the key over in his fingers.

VICTOR (CONT'D)

The Smilleys are circling this
street. Martin's right about that
much.

(beat)

When the time comes, and it's coming, I want the person who holds that key to remember that this empire started in a room smaller than your closet.

MARC
(looking up at the boarded windows)
Why are you giving it to me now?
I'm not twenty-five.

VICTOR
Because in two years, everybody will be giving you things. They'll want something back.
(beat)
This one's free.

Marc closes his hand around the key. He hugs his grandfather. Victor stiffens and then allows it, patting Marc's back twice, the way a Donohue man hugs.

VICTOR (CONT'D)
Happy birthday, son.

MARC
(into his shoulder)
Thank you, Granddaddy.

Behind them, the sun comes up over Sweet Auburn and hits the stone letters: HOTEL DONOHUE.

CUT TO:

2 INT. RAVENHURST — ESTHER'S DRESSING ROOM — MORNING
Wednesday, January 5, 2005 — 7:12 AM EST

A cathedral of closets: floor-to-ceiling glass cabinets of shoes, and gowns on rolling racks in plastic sleeves.

ESTHER SMILLEY (22), in a silk robe with a coffee in hand, walks the length of the room and doesn't look at anything in particular.

NANNY BEA (43) enters, carrying a garment in a black steamer bag.

BEA
Good morning, madam. The Valentino came back from the steamer.

ESTHER
What Valentino?

BEA
(evenly)
The red one.

Esther stops.

ESTHER
I didn't ask for the red one to
be steamed.

BEA
No, madam. Your grandmother did.
Last night. At eleven forty-five.
With a note.

She holds out a folded card. Esther reads it.

INSERT — THE CARD, in Odessa's grand, looping hand: "Just
in case. — 0."

Esther hands it back without expression.

ESTHER
I'm not going, Bea.

BEA
Of course not, madam.

Bea hangs the garment bag on a hook and unzips it halfway.
A flash of scarlet silk shows: bias-cut, floor-length,
devastating.

ESTHER
I mean it.

BEA
I've no doubt, madam.

She leaves. Esther stands alone, looking at the red dress.

She reaches out and touches the silk.

Then she zips the bag closed, firmly, all the way to the
top.

She leaves the bag on the hook.

SMASH CUT TO:

MAIN TITLES — "KINGDOM"

ACT ONE**3 INT. BELLE RIVE – THE BREAKFAST ROOM – MORNING**

Wednesday, January 5, 2005 – 8:20 AM EST

A sunny Mediterranean breakfast room overlooking the river. The table is covered with birthday chaos: a stack of pancakes with a lit candle stuck in the top, gift bags, and a HELIUM BALLOON shaped like a gold "23."

NATASHA, ROBERT, GRACE, and NANA RUBY are gathered. Marc comes in the door from the terrace.

ALL
(singing, badly)
Happy birthday to you–

MARC
(covering his ears,
delighted)
No. No. Stop. Grace, you're a
professional, you should be
ashamed–

GRACE
(singing louder,
deliberately off-key)
–happy BIRTHday, dear MAAAARC–

NANA RUBY
(over them all, in a
gorgeous church alto)
Happy birthday to youuuu.

Everyone stops and stares at Nana Ruby.

NANA RUBY (CONT'D)
(shrugging)
Somebody had to sing it right.

Applause. Marc blows out the candle on the pancakes. Natasha kisses him on both cheeks and holds his face.

NATASHA
Twenty-three years ago at this
exact minute, I was screaming at
your father in Crawford Long
Hospital.

ROBERT

She called me a word I'd never
heard before, and I've defended
bikers.

NATASHA

You deserved it.

ROBERT

I did deserve it.

Marc sits. Grace shoves a gift bag at him.

GRACE

Mine first.

He pulls out a T-SHIRT: a photo of his own face in the
paper crown from Egleston, captioned "FUNNIEST MAN ALIVE
(ACCORDING TO HIM)."

MARC

I'm wearing this tonight.

NATASHA

You are not.

MARC

Under the tux. Like Superman.

Robert slides a slim leather box across the table.

ROBERT

From me and your mother.

Marc opens it: a vintage steel watch, beautiful and
simple.

ROBERT (CONT'D)

Patek Philippe. 1964. The year
the Civil Rights Act was signed.
I outbid a man from Geneva who
cried.

MARC

(stunned)

Daddy.

ROBERT

Every man in this family ought to
wear the year the law finally
caught up with us.
(beat)

You earned a law degree at
nineteen and never practiced a
day. I'm hoping it shames you
into it.

MARC
(laughing, putting it
on)
It won't.

ROBERT
I know. But I'm your father. I
have to try.

NANA RUBY
(setting down a plate
of bacon)
And from me, the same thing I
give you every year.

MARC
The cake.

NANA RUBY
Tonight. You touch it before
nine, I'll know. I'll know,
Marc-Anthony. I've got people.

Natasha's BlackBerry buzzes. She reads it and laughs out
loud.

NATASHA
Your Uncle Alvin.

MARC
From Miami?

NATASHA
He's sending you a gift. It's
arriving at noon. On a flatbed.

MARC
A flatbed?

NATASHA
(reading)
"Tell the birthday boy it's a
1969 Harley Shovelhead, it's
cherry red, and if his
grandmother asks, it's a
bicycle."

GRACE

He is NOT going to let Grandma
Joan see a motorcycle.

MARC

(beaming)

I love that man. He's a disaster.
I love him.

Laughter. Natasha looks across the table at her husband,
just for a second.

Robert is checking his BlackBerry under the table.
Whatever he reads makes him put it away quickly, face
down.

Natasha's smile doesn't falter. Nana Ruby, pouring coffee,
glances at Robert's pocket, then at Natasha. She says
nothing.

MARC (CONT'D)

(oblivious, stuffing
pancake in his mouth)

Best birthday ever. And it's
eight-thirty in the morning.

CUT TO:

**4 INT. MERRIWEATHER & SONS FUNERAL HOME – THE FAMILY
PARLOR – MORNING**

Wednesday, January 5, 2005 – 9:34 AM EST

The velvet parlor. The organ music. Silas sits in his
wingback chair.

OTIS opens the door. MAMA DEE enters in her church coat
and hat, carrying a covered pie dish in both hands the way
a diplomat carries a treaty.

Silas rises. It's old-school manners.

SILAS

Dolores.

MAMA DEE

Silas.

She sets the pie on the side table and uncovers it: sweet
potato, perfectly browned, with a lattice top.

SILAS

You brought pie to a man who sent
you a funeral wreath.

MAMA DEE

I brought pie to a man I've known
since we were twelve years old at
the Royal Peacock, when you tried
to steal my seat and I stepped on
your hand in my Sunday shoes.

SILAS

(despite himself,
touching his knuckles)
You broke two fingers.

MAMA DEE

You were in my seat.

He gestures. She sits on the settee. He sits back down.
Otis stands by the door.

SILAS

The wreath was a question,
Dolores.

MAMA DEE

I know it was, baby. That's why I
brought an answer.

She folds her hands in her lap.

MAMA DEE (CONT'D)

We didn't do it.

SILAS

The coin says you did.

MAMA DEE

The coin is a lie.

(beat)

I'm here to swear it on the Code.
From him. Not a Blackwater hand
touched Lamar Whitlock. Sovereign
doesn't do parks. Sovereign
doesn't do deacons. And Sovereign
doesn't break his word to a man
he shook hands with in my
restaurant.

Silas studies her for a long time. The organ plays softly.

SILAS

Then who did?

MAMA DEE

That's what we're going to find out.

SILAS

And if you don't?

MAMA DEE

We will.

SILAS

You'll understand if my faith in ghosts has limits.

MAMA DEE

I understand, Silas. That's why he said to tell you: you'll have proof.

(beat)

By Friday.

A beat. Silas leans back.

SILAS

Friday.

MAMA DEE

Friday.

SILAS

(slowly)

Lamar's funeral is Saturday. Eleven a.m. Greater Cascade Baptist. Four hundred people are going to walk out of that church and look at me, Dolores. And they're going to want to know what I did about it.

(beat)

If I don't have an answer by Friday night, I'll give them one.

MAMA DEE

(rising, picking up her purse)

Then eat the pie, Silas. You're going to need your strength to apologize.

She walks to the door. Otis opens it for her.

SILAS
(calling after her)
Dolores.

She turns.

SILAS (CONT'D)
If it wasn't y'all...
(beat)
Then who in this city wants you
and me in a war?

Mama Dee looks at him for a long moment.

MAMA DEE
Somebody who's never had to bury
anybody.

She leaves. Silas looks at the pie. He takes a silver fork from his breast pocket, where he apparently keeps one, and takes a bite.

He closes his eyes.

SILAS
(to Otis, grudging)
Damn, that woman can cook.

CUT TO:

5 INT. BSI TOWER — 57TH FLOOR — "THE GHOST ROOM" — DAY
Wednesday, January 5, 2005 — 10:18 AM EST

A windowless server room humming with cold air. Racks of blinking servers. Three curved monitors glow in the dark.

KEISHA "GHOST" LATTIMORE (25) sits cross-legged in an ergonomic chair in a hoodie, eating dry Froot Loops out of the box.

Marc enters in a suit, the new Patek on his wrist and a slice of pancake wrapped in a napkin.

MARC
I brought you breakfast.

KEISHA
(not looking up)
It's a pancake in a napkin.

MARC

It's a birthday pancake in a napkin. It's blessed.

She takes it without comment and eats it with one hand while she types with the other.

KEISHA

Happy birthday. Two things.
(tapping a monitor)
One. Warren Hughes.

A phone record fills the screen: highlighted lines.

KEISHA (CONT'D)

His personal cell, not his department phone. Monday night, ten-oh-three p.m., a four-minute call to the WBKG assignment desk.
(beat)

That's eleven minutes after the first officer radioed in the coin, and forty minutes before Celeste went live.

MARC

(quietly)
So it's him.

KEISHA

It's him. And he called the same number twice on December twenty-first. The day after your sister was sworn in.

MARC

He's been feeding them since day one.

KEISHA

You want me to leak it back? Put it in front of your sister?

MARC

(beat)
No. If this came from us, she'd have to ask how we got it.

KEISHA

So what do you do with it?

MARC
(pocketing the
printout)
Something stupid and brotherly.
Two?

Keisha pulls up a photo: a close-up of a fake coin next to a map of the world with small red dots.

KEISHA
The six-crest coin. Real onyx,
laser-cut with a five-axis
machine. There are maybe eleven
shops on Earth that do that kind
of work in stone at that
tolerance. Four in Italy. Two in
Germany. One in Hong Kong. Two in
India. One in Israel.
(beat)
And one in South Africa.

MARC
That's eleven.

KEISHA
I'm hacking all of them. It'll
take a week. Maybe two. Some of
them still keep paper records.
(beat)
Whoever ordered these didn't use
a jeweler down the street, Marc.
They went international. That
takes money and planning.

MARC
And time.

KEISHA
Months, probably.

Marc sits on the edge of her desk. He thinks.

MARC
So whoever this is started
planning before the Smilleys
announced. Before my sister was
sworn in. Before any of it.

KEISHA
Maybe.

MARC
(to himself)

Somebody's been sitting at our table longer than we have.

His RAZR buzzes. He answers.

MARC (CONT'D)

Roman.

INTERCUT WITH:

**6 EXT. PIEDMONT PARK – THE 10TH STREET ENTRANCE –
CONTINUOUS**

Roman stands near the park gate in a black jacket, looking up at a traffic camera on a pole.

ROMAN

There's a city traffic camera at 10th and Piedmont. Covers the only lot within four hundred yards of where Lamar was found. Ghost pulled the footage.

MARC

And?

ROMAN

A white cargo van. No windows. Parked at six-forty Monday night, gone at seven-oh-five. Plates came back stolen, off a church van in Macon.

MARC

Driver?

ROMAN

You can't see a face. But he's tall. White. Moves like a soldier.

(beat)

Not a street guy, Marc. Somebody trained.

END INTERCUT.

Marc lowers the phone. Keisha has stopped eating.

KEISHA

Hired help.

MARC
(standing, very
quietly)
Then somebody's paying him.
(beat)
Find me the someone.

He pockets the phone and walks toward the door. He stops.

MARC (CONT'D)
Ghost. You coming tonight?

KEISHA
(back to her monitors)
To a party with three hundred
people in tuxedos? No.

MARC
There's a duck.

KEISHA
(beat)
...What kind of duck?

MARC
A duck that won the lottery.

KEISHA
(sighing)
I'll think about it.

He grins and exits.

CUT TO:

**7 INT. CITY HALL EAST — APD HEADQUARTERS — CHIEF'S
OFFICE — DAY**

Wednesday, January 5, 2005 — 11:06 AM EST

Elxa at her desk, mid-argument, with Deputy Chief WARREN
HUGHES (46) standing in front of it.

HUGHES
—twenty-four-hour surveillance on
a funeral home is overtime we
don't have, Chief. Four officers.
Three shifts. That's the whole
Zone 4 budget for January.

ELXA
Then take it out of February.

HUGHES
February's already spoken for.

ELXA
Then take it out of the
command-staff Christmas party.

HUGHES
(a tight smile)
That was in December.

ELXA
Then take it out of next
December's.

Hughes shifts his weight.

HUGHES
Silas Merriweather has buried
half this city's grandmothers,
Chief. The community won't like
seeing a police car outside his
funeral home during a wake.

ELXA
The community will like it a lot
less if half the West End is on
fire by Saturday.
(beat)
The car stays, Warren. Unmarked.
Rotating. Signed off by me.

HUGHES
Yes, Chief.

He turns to go. At the door, he pauses, casual.

HUGHES (CONT'D)
Enjoy the party tonight.

ELXA
(not looking up)
What party?

HUGHES
Your brother's birthday. It was
in the Sentinel.
(beat)
I hear the Mayor's going.

He smiles and leaves.

Elxa sits still. She picks up the phone and puts it down again.

She looks at the framed photo on the wall: her father-in-law, Harold Jackson, grinning between three mayors.

ELXA
(to herself)
Of course she's going.

FADE OUT.

ACT TWO

8 INT. HARMONY'S TOWNHOUSE — LINDBERGH — LIVING ROOM — DAY

Wednesday, January 5, 2005 — 2:07 PM EST

A small two-story rental townhouse off Piedmont Road: IKEA furniture, a secondhand sofa, and toys everywhere. There's a real estate license framed on the wall, a pile of yellow "HAVE YOU SEEN DEE?" flyers on the dining table, and a photograph of a smiling young barber on the bookshelf.

HARMONY DIVINE (22), in sweats with her hair in a scarf, opens the door.

ESTHER stands there in jeans, a cashmere turtleneck, and sunglasses, holding two bottles of wine in one hand and a thick legal folder in the other. Crowe waits by the Maybach at the curb, looking at the townhouse the way he'd look at a bank vault with no lock.

ESTHER

I said wine and a lawyer.

HARMONY

Where's the lawyer?

ESTHER

(holding up the folder)

The lawyer faxed.

Harmony laughs and pulls her inside.

LATER. The two of them are on the sofa with glasses of very expensive wine in mismatched IKEA tumblers. The folder is open on the coffee table.

ESTHER (CONT'D)

—so my attorney says Georgia's grandparent-visitation statute is narrow. They have to show that denying visitation would harm the child. Not the grandmother. The child.

HARMONY

So Gloria can't win?

ESTHER

Gloria can make it very expensive
and very annoying for you to win.
That's different.

Harmony curls her legs under her.

HARMONY

She offered a deal. Through
Amond.

ESTHER

What deal?

HARMONY

One Sunday a month. Church and
dinner. Home by six. She
withdraws the petition.

ESTHER

(sipping)

And?

HARMONY

And I don't know. She's not a bad
person, Esther. She's a
principal. She cried in the
hallway at Lyric's christening.
She just...

(beat)

She's from that world. Belmont
Crest. Where everybody gets what
they want because they've always
gotten what they want.

Esther sets down her glass.

ESTHER

Then don't give it to her.

HARMONY

It's one Sunday.

ESTHER

It's never one Sunday, Harm.

(beat)

Listen to me. The moment you say
yes, you've told them the price.
One Sunday this year. Two next
year. Then it's summers in
Belmont Crest, and a school
there, and an account at the
Club, and one day Lyric comes

home and calls you "Harmony"
instead of "Mama," because that's
what they call you in that house.

Harmony stares at her.

HARMONY

That's dark.

ESTHER

That's families like theirs.

(beat)

And families like mine.

A quiet beat. Harmony looks at her best friend: the heiress, the ice queen, the woman who hugged her in the marble foyer two days ago like they were still eighteen.

HARMONY

You'd tell me no.

ESTHER

I'd tell you "not yet." Never
give up your leverage for free.
Let them earn it.

Harmony nods slowly. She picks up her wine.

HARMONY

Speaking of families like theirs.

ESTHER

No.

HARMONY

You don't even know what I'm
going to say.

ESTHER

You're going to say you're going
to the Donohue heir's party
tonight.

HARMONY

I'm going to say I'M going to
Marc's party tonight. He's
Lyric's godfather. He invited me
personally. He called, Esther. He
called my house phone himself to
make sure I'd come.

(beat)

And you're invited.

ESTHER

How do you—

HARMONY

It's on CrestWatch. "Welcome,
neighbor." Everybody in Atlanta
knows the old lady invited you.
(leaning in)
Come with me.

ESTHER

No.

HARMONY

Why not?

ESTHER

My father would disown me.

HARMONY

Your father built you a
skyscraper. He's not disowning
you over a birthday party.

ESTHER

Harm, our families have hated
each other since 1952.

HARMONY

Our families? Esther, my family
hates the Atlanta Water
Department. That's it. That's the
whole list.

Esther laughs despite herself. But then she looks away,
toward the window.

ESTHER

(quiet)
I can't.

HARMONY

Can't, or won't?

A long pause.

ESTHER

(carefully)
There are people I'm not ready to
be in a room with.

HARMONY

Who? The Donohues? They're just rich people, girl. You're rich people. You'll recognize each other.

ESTHER

(standing, collecting her sunglasses)
Take pictures of the duck.

HARMONY

What duck?

ESTHER

(at the door)
Apparently there's a duck. It's on CrestWatch.

She's gone. Harmony sits alone on her secondhand sofa with a glass of four-hundred-dollar wine.

She picks up the legal folder. On the cover, in Esther's precise handwriting, a sticky note:

INSERT – STICKY NOTE: "Not yet. Let them earn it. – E"

Harmony looks at it for a long moment.

Then she picks up the phone and dials.

HARMONY

(into phone)
Hi, Mama. Can you keep Lyric tonight? I'm going to a party.
(beat)
No, not that kind. The kind with a duck.

CUT TO:

9 INT. DONOHUE TOWER – MARTIN'S OFFICE – 86TH FLOOR – DAY

Wednesday, January 5, 2005 – 3:12 PM EST

Martin's immaculate office. A garment bag with a tuxedo hangs on the coat rack.

On his desk, on a sheet of black tissue paper, lies an old book in a green cloth binding. He is wrapping it with surgical precision: black paper, gold ribbon, and corners folded at perfect forty-five-degree angles.

INSERT – THE BOOK'S SPINE: "THE PRINCE – Niccolò Machiavelli – First English Edition, 1640."

He opens the cover before he finishes wrapping it. With a fountain pen, in small perfect handwriting, he writes an inscription.

INSERT – THE INSCRIPTION: "To the Prince. May you always be loved and feared in exactly the right proportion. Your loyal cousin, M."

He blows gently on the ink. He closes the book and finishes the wrapping.

His desk phone rings. He glances at the caller ID: an internal extension. He answers.

MARTIN

Martin Olson.

(listening)

Yes, Aunt Natasha.

(beat)

Of course I'll be there. I wouldn't miss it.

(beat)

Yes. Delighted.

He hangs up. He sets the wrapped book on top of his briefcase.

He looks out his window. Two floors up is Victor's office. Across Peachtree, the Smilley sign glows platinum in the afternoon light.

He takes out his personal cell phone, a slim black flip phone, and looks at it. No messages.

He puts it back in his pocket.

CUT TO:

10 INT. FULTON COUNTY COURTHOUSE – DISTRICT ATTORNEY'S OFFICE – DAY

Wednesday, January 5, 2005 – 4:03 PM EST

Arianna at her desk, reviewing a brief with a red pen. On the corner of her desk sits a small wrapped gift with a silver bow and a card in Marc's name.

A knock. ASSISTANT DA PRESTON enters, pushing a squeaking mail cart piled high with dusty accordion files.

PRESTON

Madam DA. Cold case unit, as ordered. Four investigators start Monday. This is the first load from the closet.

ARIANNA

How many?

PRESTON

Two hundred and six in this batch. Unsolved homicides and missing persons, 1998 to 2003. I figured you'd want to see the list before we assign them out.

He hands her a typed list, several pages long, stapled. She takes it and skims.

ARIANNA

Thank you, Preston. Leave the cart.

He exits. Arianna flips through the pages casually, reading case names, dates, and neighborhoods. It's the work of a good prosecutor.

Page three. Her pen stops.

INSERT — THE LIST: "MP-2002-0014 — DIVINE, DARNELL M. — Missing Person — Reported 01/02/2002 — Last Seen: Northside Dr. NW — Status: INACTIVE."

She looks at the line for a long time.

Then she looks at the cart. She stands and walks to it. She runs her finger down the labels of the accordion files until she finds one: MP-2002-0014.

She pulls it out. It's thin and dusty, with a coffee ring on the cover.

She holds it in both hands. She doesn't open it.

Through her window, the courthouse clock begins to chime four-fifteen.

She walks back to her desk. She opens her bottom drawer and places the file inside, face down, under a box of tissues.

She closes the drawer.

She picks up the small gift with the silver bow and the card that says "Marc." She holds it in her lap like something she needs to hold on to.

ARIANNA

(quietly, to herself)

It's his birthday.

(beat)

It's his birthday. Not today.

She stands, grabs her coat, and leaves the office. The file stays in the drawer.

FADE OUT.

ACT THREE**11 INT. BELLE RIVE – THE GRAND BALLROOM – EVENING**

Wednesday, January 5, 2005 – 7:31 PM EST

The palazzo's ballroom is transformed: gold and ivory flowers cascading from the ceiling, three hundred candles, and a fourteen-piece BAND setting up on a riser. French doors are open onto a heated terrace above the river. Waiters in white jackets polish crystal.

In the center of the room, on a mirrored pedestal, stands the ICE SCULPTURE: a magnificent swan wearing a large ice crown. It looks exactly like a duck that won the lottery.

NATASHA, in a black column gown and diamonds, stands in front of it with BRIELLE (21), who holds a clipboard to her chest like a shield.

NATASHA

Brielle.

BRIELLE

Yes, Mrs. Bullock.

NATASHA

What is that.

BRIELLE

It's the ice sculpture.

NATASHA

It's a duck.

BRIELLE

It's a swan, ma'am. Wearing a crown.

NATASHA

It's a duck that won the lottery.

BRIELLE

(miserably)

Yes, ma'am. Your son requested it specifically. In writing.

Natasha stares at the duck for a long moment.

NATASHA

(finally)

Put a light on it. If we're going to have a duck, it's going to be the best-lit duck in Georgia.

BRIELLE
(relieved, writing)
Best-lit duck. Yes, ma'am.

Through a service door, NANA RUBY enters, followed by two waiters carrying the THREE-TIER POUND CAKE on a silver stand as carefully as if it were a newborn.

NANA RUBY
Easy. EASY. You drop it, you're dead, and I'll make you bake another one in heaven.

WINSTON FAIRLEY (62), on loan from the Manor for the night, supervises the bar with regal calm.

WINSTON
(to a young bartender)
The Krug for the family. The Veuve for the guests. And the Cristal for no one, because Mr. Alvin sent it, and Mrs. Joan will ask where it came from.

The young bartender nods, terrified.

Natasha surveys the room. It's perfect.

Then her eyes go to the terrace doors. Robert stands outside in his tuxedo, alone, on his BlackBerry again, speaking low.

Natasha watches him for a moment. Then she turns back to the room, bright as the chandeliers.

NATASHA
(to everyone)
Doors in thirty minutes, people. Somebody find my son and tell him if he's wearing that T-shirt under his tuxedo, I'll know.

CUT TO:

12 EXT. BELLE RIVE – THE MOTOR COURT – NIGHT

Wednesday, January 5, 2005 – 8:06 PM EST

A circular gravel drive lit by torches, with a fountain in the center. A line of luxury cars inches toward the grand steps: Bentleys, Maybachs, and a few town cars with government plates. VALETS in white gloves.

GUESTS in black tie and couture climb the steps. It's Atlanta's Black aristocracy: judges, CEOs, athletes, pastors, and politicians.

A black Rolls-Royce pulls up. Winston, who has come out to receive them, opens the door himself.

VICTOR steps out in a tuxedo, then offers his hand to JOAN, in midnight blue with the Washington pearls again.

Then SIMONE DONOHUE (94), in dove-gray silk and a mink stole, a triple strand of glowing WHITE PEARLS around her throat, takes Victor's arm and steps onto the gravel as if she owns it. She does.

Winston discreetly takes a flat, worn leather JEWELRY CASE from the car and tucks it under his arm.

SIMONE
(to Winston, low)
Keep it close.

WINSTON
Always, madam.

A second car: a sleek Lincoln with a City of Atlanta seal on the plate. MAYOR JOSEPHINE WHITAKER (55) climbs out in a sequined gown, political smile already on.

MAYOR WHITAKER
Victor!

VICTOR
Madam Mayor.

They embrace, cheek to cheek, a little too warmly. Joan watches from the steps with a pleasant smile that does not reach her eyes.

Behind them, a silver-haired woman in a vintage Chanel suit with a notepad in her evening bag steps out of a cab. BERNADETTE SINCLAIR (59), the Sentinel's society columnist, surveys the scene the way a hawk surveys a field.

BERNADETTE
(to herself, delighted)
Oh, the Washington pearls again.
Darling, she means it.

Then a red Mercedes convertible, top up in the cold, swings in too fast. CELESTE VAUGHN (24) steps out in a scarlet silk gown slit to the hip, a red satin clutch, and red lips.

Several heads turn. Celeste loves it.

Behind her, a silver Jaguar. CAMILLE RHODES (38) steps out alone in a sleek black gown with her hair swept up. She's classic, understated, and scentless.

She pauses on the steps and looks up at the glowing palazzo. For just a moment she looks like a woman walking into a house that isn't hers.

Then she squares her shoulders and goes in.

CUT TO:

13 INT. BELLE RIVE – THE GRAND SALON – NIGHT
Wednesday, January 5, 2005 – 8:32 PM EST

The party is in full swing. Three hundred guests. The band plays jazz standards. Laughter, crystal, and conversation at a roar.

Marc is at the center of it all in a perfectly cut tuxedo, the Patek on his wrist, being hugged, kissed, and congratulated by an endless line. He's radiant and in his element.

Celeste appears at his side in red and slips her arm through his.

CELESTE
Happy birthday, Mr. Bullock.

MARC
(looking at her dress)
You said you'd wear red.

CELESTE
I always keep my promises.

MARC
You look like a fire alarm.

CELESTE
(delighted)
The good kind?

MARC
The kind you pull on purpose.

She kisses him. Cameras flash from somewhere.

AMOND BAKER (22), in a sleek tuxedo, pushes through the crowd holding two glasses of champagne. He hands one to Marc.

AMOND
Twenty-three. How's it feel?

MARC
Like twenty-two, but with better lighting.

Martin approaches with Mallory and Peter behind him. He holds out the black-and-gold package with both hands, formal and perfect.

MARTIN
Happy birthday, cousin.

MARC
(genuinely surprised)
Martin. You didn't have to.

MARTIN
Of course I did.

Marc unwraps it right there, the way he unwraps everything, like a kid. He sees the green cloth binding and the spine, THE PRINCE. He opens the cover and reads the inscription.

His smile holds, but something in it shifts.

MARC
(reading aloud,
lightly)
"May you always be loved and
feared in exactly the right
proportion."
(looking up)
First English edition?

MARTIN
1640.

MARC

That's beautiful, Martin. Really.

(beat)

You know Machiavelli wrote this
after they tortured him, right?
Six drops on the strappado. And
then he sat down and wrote a job
application to the family that
did it.

The people nearby laugh. Martin smiles his perfect smile.

MARTIN

I know. That's why I thought of
you.

A beat. Nobody quite knows how to take that.

MALLORY

(breaking it,
cheerfully)

Happy birthday, cousin! My gift
is emotional support and a sneak
peek of Grace and Glory.

MARC

(hugging her)

My favorite gift.

PETER

(shaking Marc's hand
warmly)

Twenty-three. I remember holding
you at the christening. You
screamed at the Bishop.

MARC

He had it coming.

The crowd shifts. ARIANNA CUMMINGS (22), in a slim silver
gown, slides in and hands Marc the small box with the
silver bow.

ARIANNA

Happy birthday.

MARC

Ari.

He opens it: a pair of cufflinks, gold, engraved with the
scales of justice.

ARIANNA
So you remember that some of us
still believe in rules.

MARC
(putting them on right
away, over his own)
I'll wear them to every crime I
commit.

ARIANNA
(smiling, a little
tight)
Don't joke.

He kisses her cheek. Behind her, a young woman in a
borrowed black dress and simple silver hoops is making her
way through the crowd, looking a little overwhelmed.

Harmony.

MARC
(lighting up)
HARMONY!

He practically lifts her off her feet in a hug.

HARMONY
Happy birthday, Uncle Pony!

MARC
She still calls me that?

HARMONY
Every single day. Your pony is a
household name. We're very proud.

She turns and sees Arianna. Her face changes. It's
recognition, and hope.

HARMONY (CONT'D)
Oh my God. You're the District
Attorney.

Arianna goes perfectly still.

ARIANNA
I am.

HARMONY
(sticking out her hand,
eager)

Harmony Divine. I'm Lyric's mom.
Lyric's Marc's goddaughter.
(beat, her voice
softening)
I was going to come to your
office this week. About my
brother. Darnell Divine. He went
missing New Year's Eve 2001, and
nobody ever—

She stops herself and laughs, embarrassed.

HARMONY (CONT'D)
I'm sorry. It's a party. It's his
birthday. I'm doing that thing
where I talk about Dee to
everybody. My mother says I have
to stop.

For a moment, Arianna can't move.

Marc sees it. He steps in smoothly, a hand on each of
their backs.

MARC
Harmony's been putting up flyers
for three years. Every week. By
herself.

ARIANNA
(recovering, taking
Harmony's hand)
I've seen them. The yellow ones.

HARMONY
Those are mine!

ARIANNA
(quietly)
Come see me, Harmony.
(beat)
Thursday. Tomorrow. My office.
Ten o'clock.

HARMONY
(overwhelmed)
Really?

ARIANNA
Really.

HARMONY
(squeezing her hand)

Thank you. Thank you. You don't
know what that means.

ARIANNA
(barely)
I think I do.

Harmony is swept away by the crowd toward the bar. Arianna
turns and looks straight at Marc.

Neither says anything. The band plays on. Three hundred
people laugh around them.

Arianna turns and walks toward the terrace doors, fast.

Marc watches her go. Then he takes a long drink of
champagne.

FADE OUT.

ACT FOUR**14 INT. BELLE RIVE – ROBERT'S STUDY – NIGHT**

Wednesday, January 5, 2005 – 8:52 PM EST

A wood-paneled study off the main hall, with law books, leather chairs, and a humidor. The door is open six inches. The party roars faintly beyond it.

Inside, Victor and Mayor Whitaker stand by the fireplace, each holding a glass of bourbon, speaking low.

MAYOR WHITAKER

—and the City Council is already whispering, Victor. Warren Hughes is buying drinks for half of them. By spring someone will call for a hearing.

VICTOR

Then let them hold a hearing. Her record will speak.

MAYOR WHITAKER

Her record isn't what worries me.
(beat)
If anyone ever finds out about our conversations in November—

VICTOR

(quietly)
There were no conversations in November, Jo.

MAYOR WHITAKER

(beat)
Of course. My mistake.

VICTOR

You chose the finest detective in this city. I merely agreed with your judgment. Enthusiastically. Twice.

MAYOR WHITAKER

(sipping)
And Robert agreed with it once.

VICTOR

Robert is a very agreeable man.

She almost laughs.

15 EXT. BELLE RIVE – THE MAIN HALLWAY – CONTINUOUS

Elxa, in a simple black gown with her hair up, holding a club soda, is walking toward the powder room. She passes the half-open door of her father's study.

She hears nothing clearly: a murmur, a laugh. But through the six-inch gap she SEES:

Her grandfather and the Mayor, heads together by the fire. The Mayor touches Victor's arm, familiar, grateful. Victor raises his glass to her, a small private toast.

Elxa stops walking.

The Mayor glances toward the door. Elxa steps back before she can be seen.

She stands in the hallway with her back against the wall and the club soda in her hand. The party roars around the corner.

JEREMY (O.S.)

There you are.

Jeremy appears with two plates of shrimp.

JEREMY (CONT'D)

I got you the big ones. I had to fight a judge.

ELXA

(not moving)

The Mayor's in Daddy's study with Granddaddy.

JEREMY

(glancing at the door)

Okay?

ELXA

Alone. With the door almost closed.

JEREMY

(carefully)

Babe, the Mayor goes everywhere. She was at the Smilley ribbon-cutting Monday.

ELXA
She didn't toast Lucius Smilley
in his study.

Jeremy looks at the door, then at his wife.

JEREMY
You want me to go in there and
ask?

ELXA
(beat, taking a shrimp)
No.
(beat)
I don't want to know tonight.

She eats the shrimp and walks back toward the party.
Jeremy watches her go, then looks at the study door for a
long moment before he follows.

CUT TO:

16 EXT. BELLE RIVE – THE RIVER TERRACE – NIGHT

Wednesday, January 5, 2005 – 9:04 PM EST

A stone terrace hanging over the dark Chattahoochee. Heat
lamps glow orange. Fairy lights in the bare trees. A few
couples stand at the balustrade, laughing, but this end of
the terrace is quiet.

Harmony stands alone at the railing with a glass of
champagne, looking down at the black river.

Amond comes out through the French doors, two glasses in
hand. He hesitates, then walks over and stands beside her.
Not too close.

AMOND
You look nice.

HARMONY
(not looking at him)
It's borrowed.

AMOND
It still looks nice.

A beat. She glances at him.

HARMONY
You look nice too. Not borrowed,
I'm guessing.

AMOND

Armani.

HARMONY

Of course.

He offers her the second glass. She lifts her own, still half-full. He sets his down on the railing.

AMOND

I talked to my mother.

HARMONY

I figured.

AMOND

She said she's seen Lyric eleven times. Since she was born. She counted.

(beat)

She cried, Harm. In the kitchen. My mother doesn't cry.

Harmony's face softens despite herself.

AMOND (CONT'D)

She'll drop the petition. Today. If you give her one Sunday a month. Church and dinner. Home by six. And you're welcome to come to all of it.

Harmony looks at the river for a long time.

HARMONY

Your mother's not a bad woman.

AMOND

No.

HARMONY

She's just used to getting things.

AMOND

(beat)

That's fair.

HARMONY

Everybody on this side of those gates is used to getting things, Amond. You. Marc. Your mother. It's not your fault. It's just the water here.

AMOND

That's not an answer.

She turns to him. There's no anger in her face tonight. Just caution, and something like sadness.

HARMONY

Not yet.

AMOND

Harm—

HARMONY

Not yet, Amond. I'm not saying no. I'm saying you all have to earn it. Not with money. Not with lawyers. Not with a pony.

(beat)

You have to show up. For a while. And then we'll see.

AMOND

(hurt)

She's her grandmother.

HARMONY

And I'm her mother. I was her mother alone for two years and eight months while everybody on this side of the ravine sent checks.

(beat)

Not yet.

She sets her glass on the railing beside his untouched one and walks back inside, into the music.

Amond stands alone at the balustrade. He looks at the two glasses side by side.

He picks up the full one and drinks it in one swallow.

CUT TO:

17 INT. BELLE RIVE – THE POWDER ROOM – NIGHT

Wednesday, January 5, 2005 – 9:09 PM EST

An ornate powder room with gilded mirrors, a velvet settee, and a basket of monogrammed hand towels. The party is muffled through the door.

Harmony stands at the sink, blotting her eyes with a tissue, careful not to smudge her mascara.

The door opens. GLORIA BAKER (48) enters in an elegant emerald gown, a sequined clutch in her hand.

They see each other in the mirror. Both freeze.

GLORIA

(beat)

I can come back.

HARMONY

No. It's fine. I'm done.

She isn't done. She dabs at her eye again. Gloria hesitates, then sets her clutch on the counter and takes a monogrammed towel from the basket. She holds it out.

GLORIA

Those tissues are terrible.
They'll leave lint in your
lashes.

Harmony takes the towel after a moment.

HARMONY

Thank you.

A long, awkward beat. Two women at two sinks.

GLORIA

Amond talked to you.

HARMONY

Yes.

GLORIA

And?

HARMONY

(quietly)

Not yet, Mrs. Baker.

Gloria takes this in. It hurts, visibly. She nods slowly.

GLORIA
I understand.

HARMONY
Do you?

GLORIA
(meeting her eyes in
the mirror)
I was twenty-five when I had
Amond. Curtis was finishing
dental school at Meharry and we
had nothing. A one-bedroom in
Nashville with a hot plate. His
mother came to see the baby
exactly once. She wore white
gloves and didn't take them off,
and she told me I was holding him
wrong.
(beat)
I swore I'd never be that
grandmother.

Harmony turns from the mirror to look at her.

GLORIA (CONT'D)
And then I served you papers at
your job.
(beat)
I'm sorry for that. For how. Not
for wanting her. For how.

Harmony wasn't expecting an apology. She doesn't know what
to do with it.

HARMONY
She likes greens.

GLORIA
(a wet laugh)
I know. I found out yesterday.

HARMONY
She likes them with hot sauce. A
lot of hot sauce. Like, a
concerning amount of hot sauce
for a two-year-old.

GLORIA
(laughing)
That's Curtis. That's all Curtis.

For a moment they are just two women laughing about a child they both love.

Then it passes. Harmony sets the towel down.

HARMONY
My lawyer will still be at the
hearing.

GLORIA
(nodding)
So will mine.
(beat)
But I'm glad we talked, Harmony.

HARMONY
(at the door, beat)
Me too, Mrs. Baker.

She goes. Gloria turns to the mirror, alone, and fixes her lipstick with a hand that isn't quite steady.

CUT TO:

18 INT. RAVENHURST – THE GRAND FOYER – NIGHT
Wednesday, January 5, 2005 – 9:13 PM EST

The double staircase. The chandelier. The marble floor.

At the top of the stairs, Esther appears.

She's in the RED VALENTINO: floor-length silk that catches the light like fire, her hair down, one diamond at her throat. She is breathtaking. She descends the stairs slowly, one hand on the rail.

At the bottom, in a velvet chair by the fireplace, sits ODESSA in a caftan, holding a brandy. She watches her granddaughter come down with an expression of total, fierce satisfaction.

ODESSA
Well.

ESTHER
Don't.

ODESSA
I didn't say anything.

ESTHER
You said "well."

ODESSA

"Well" is not a thing. "Well" is
a vowel with ambition.

Esther reaches the bottom of the stairs. Crowe waits by
the front door, keys in hand, carefully neutral.

From the library door, LUCIUS appears in a smoking jacket
with a folded newspaper. He sees the dress and stops.

LUCIUS

Where are you going?

ESTHER

For a drive.

LUCIUS

In a Valentino.

ESTHER

I like to look nice when I drive.

LUCIUS

Esther—

ESTHER

(kissing his cheek)
I'll be back before eleven.

LUCIUS

If you walk through that gate—

ODESSA

(from her chair, not
loudly)
Lucius. Let her go.

LUCIUS

Mother, this is not—

ODESSA

Cornelius spent twenty-nine years
not walking through Alexander
Donohue's gate. Look at all the
good it did him.
(beat)
Let the girl drive.

Lucius looks from his mother to his daughter. His hand on
the newspaper trembles. He tightens his grip.

LUCIUS

(quietly)

Before eleven.

ESTHER

Before eleven.

She turns. Crowe opens the door. Cold air sweeps in.

Upstairs, on the landing, unseen, NANNY BEA stands in the shadows holding a sleeping Victoria. She watches the red dress disappear into the night.

CUT TO:

19 INT. BELLE RIVE – THE GRAND SALON – NIGHT

Wednesday, January 5, 2005 – 9:21 PM EST

The party roars on.

Near the bar, Natasha, gracious and glittering, works the room. She turns and comes face to face with Camille Rhodes in her sleek black gown.

A fraction of a beat. Then two perfect smiles.

NATASHA

Camille. How lovely. Robert said you might come.

CAMILLE

I wouldn't miss it. Happy birthday to your son, Natasha. He's a wonderful young man.

NATASHA

He is.

They air-kiss, cheek to cheek. Natasha lingers there a half second longer than she needs to. When she pulls back, her smile is warm and her eyes are not.

NATASHA (CONT'D)

You're not wearing perfume tonight.

CAMILLE

(beat)

I'm sensitive to it. In crowds.

NATASHA

How considerate of you.
(pleasantly)

Enjoy the cake. Ruby made it herself. It's the one thing in this house nobody else is allowed to touch.

She glides away. Camille stands alone at the bar and lets out a breath she didn't know she'd been holding. She signals the bartender for something stronger than champagne.

Across the room, Martin makes his way through the crowd, charming, nodding, shaking hands. He finds Robert at the other end of the bar with a scotch.

MARTIN
Uncle Robert.

ROBERT
Martin. Nice book.

MARTIN
You saw it?

ROBERT
The whole room saw it. You gave a Machiavelli to a man at his own birthday party. I've seen subtler opening statements.

MARTIN
(smiling)
It's a classic.

ROBERT
So is arsenic.

Martin laughs, pleasant, and leans on the bar beside him.

MARTIN
I actually wanted to ask your advice. Professionally.

ROBERT
I charge nine hundred an hour.

MARTIN
I'll risk it.
(lowering his voice)
DGH has some exposure in the West End. Commercial properties. With everything happening with this Blackwater business, I want to make sure we're not doing

business with anyone connected.
(beat)
You'd know better than anyone
who's connected in this city.
You've represented half of them.

Robert turns and looks at his nephew. It's a long, level,
courtroom look.

ROBERT
Martin. Can I give you some
advice for free?

MARTIN
Of course.

ROBERT
(pleasantly)
When you cross-examine a man,
never ask him a question you
haven't already answered for
yourself. Otherwise he'll just
tell you what you want to hear.
(beat)
And the jury will see you
fishing.

He pats Martin's shoulder, picks up his scotch, and walks
away.

Martin watches him go. He's not smiling.

He turns and finds himself face to face with a scarlet
gown. Celeste, a flute of champagne in her hand, has been
watching.

CELESTE
Your uncle just ate you for
dinner.

MARTIN
(recovering, smoothly)
My uncle eats everybody for
dinner. It's a family tradition.

CELESTE
Celeste Vaughn. WBKG.

MARTIN
I know who you are. You broke the
Piedmont story.

CELESTE
You watch the eleven o'clock
news?

MARTIN
(beat)
I watched that one.

She tilts her head, interested.

CELESTE
You're the cousin. The one who
works for the company.

MARTIN
Martin Olson.

CELESTE
The one who gave the Prince The
Prince.

MARTIN
(the faintest smile)
You were watching.

CELESTE
I'm a reporter. I'm always
watching.

Martin studies her. Then, lightly, as if it means nothing
at all:

MARTIN
If you ever need a source inside
this family, Miss Vaughn,
somebody who actually reads the
documents...
(he hands her a card
from his breast pocket)
...I'm very easy to find.

Celeste takes the card. She looks at it. She looks across
the room at Marc, who is dancing with Simone, laughing.
Then back at Martin.

CELESTE
Why would you help me?

MARTIN
Because I think the truth
deserves a good publicist.

He raises his glass to her and melts back into the crowd.

Celeste slips the card into her red clutch.

FADE OUT.

ACT FIVE

20 INT. BELLE RIVE – THE GRAND BALLROOM – NIGHT

Wednesday, January 5, 2005 – 9:36 PM EST

The band finishes a number. The BANDLEADER leans into his microphone.

BANDLEADER

Ladies and gentlemen, please
welcome the birthday boy's baby
sister. Miss Grace Bullock!

A ROAR. Three hundred people turn toward the stage. GRACE BULLOCK (20) steps into the spotlight in a vintage gold gown, radiant, taking the microphone off the stand like she was born holding one.

GRACE

Hi, everybody.

CROWD

Hi, Grace!

GRACE

Y'all know this one. It went
platinum in six weeks, and I've
sung it three hundred times.

(beat, finding Marc in
the crowd)

But tonight I rewrote the second
verse. For somebody who deserves
it.

(beat)

This one's called "Crown Me."
It's for my big brother.

The crowd parts around Marc. Simone is on one side of him and Celeste on the other. He puts a hand over his heart.

The band kicks in: a slow, gospel-soaked R&B groove with a Hammond organ and brushes on the snare.

GRACE (CONT'D)

(singing)

"They told me stay small, girl,
stay in your lane,
Keep your head down low when they
call your name—
But I got a crown that they can't
see,

Gold on my soul, so baby, crown
me--"

The crowd sways. Some of the older women in the room raise their hands like it's church.

Grace moves to the edge of the stage, looking right at her brother. The music softens.

GRACE (CONT'D)
(singing, the new
verse)
"You were the one when the lights
went out,
Standing at the door when I was
full of doubt,
Never asked for thanks, never
asked for praise,
Just a boy with a crown in his
yesterdays--"

Marc's eyes fill. He doesn't look away from her.

Simone, beside him, slips her hand into his.

CUT TO:

21 EXT. BELMONT CREST — THE CROWN GATE — NIGHT
Wednesday, January 5, 2005 — 9:41 PM EST

West Paces Ferry Road. The great wrought-iron gates, the limestone guardhouses, the gilded "BC," and the scorched left pillar with its bronze plaque, all lit by floodlights.

Just outside the gate, on the shoulder, a WBKG news van is parked with its mast half raised. A cameraman adjusts a light stand.

Celeste, in red, with a WBKG parka thrown over her gown, stands in front of the camera checking her makeup in a compact mirror.

CELESTE
(to the cameraman)
We go live at eleven from right here. "Inside Atlanta's party of the year." Keep the gate in the background. And the burned thing.

CAMERAMAN
It's called a pillar.

CELESTE
It's called ratings.

Headlights. A long, black MAYBACH glides up West Paces Ferry and slows. It turns in toward the gate and stops at the guardhouse.

Celeste glances over, idly curious.

The Maybach's rear window lowers.

Inside, in the glow of the floodlights, a woman in a SCARLET gown, with a single diamond at her throat, leans forward to hand an engraved invitation to the guard.

Celeste lowers her compact.

She looks down at her own red dress. Then back at the car.

CELESTE (CONT'D)
(under her breath)
You have got to be kidding me.

She squints at the rear license plate as the floodlights catch it:

INSERT — GEORGIA TAG: "SMILLEY 1"

Celeste's eyebrows rise slowly, all the way.

INT. THE CROWN GATE — GUARDHOUSE — CONTINUOUS

A small limestone booth, warm, with a bank of SECURITY MONITORS on the wall. BSI GATE OFFICER DANTE HOLLIS (30s), in BSI black with an earpiece, takes the invitation through the car window.

He reads it and his eyebrows lift. He looks at the woman in the back seat, then down at his clipboard.

OFFICER HOLLIS
Miss... Smilley?

ESTHER (O.S.)
(from the car)
Yes.

OFFICER HOLLIS
(professional, masking surprise)
One moment, ma'am. I need to radio the house.

He picks up his radio. As he does, Esther leans closer to the open window, and her eyes go past him, into the booth, to the MONITORS.

The monitors show live security feeds from Belle Rive: the motor court, the terrace, the kitchen door, and, on the largest screen, the BALLROOM.

On that screen, in grainy black and white, three hundred people sway. Grace sings on the stage. And in the center of the crowd, a young man in a tuxedo, his great-grandmother's hand in his, throws his head back and LAUGHS at something she's whispered to him.

Esther stares at the screen.

It's the exact same angle. The same tilt of the head. The same sudden, whole-body joy.

It's Victoria's laugh, on the face of a man she's spent three and a half years trying not to look at.

INTERCUT WITH:

22 INT. RAVENHURST – THE NURSERY – SAME TIME

In the dark nursery, VICTORIA SMILLEY (2), asleep in her canopy bed, turns over and giggles in her sleep. It's the same laugh.

BACK TO:

23 INT. SMILLEY MAYBACH – AT THE CROWN GATE – CONTINUOUS

Esther sits back against the leather seat, fast, as if she's been pushed.

OFFICER HOLLIS (O.S.)
(into radio)
Belle Rive, Crown Gate. I have a
Miss Esther Smilley, one guest,
requesting entry—

ESTHER
(to her driver, quiet,
urgent)
Turn the car around.

SMILLEY DRIVER
Miss Smilley?

ESTHER

Turn the car around. Now.

The officer lowers his radio, confused.

OFFICER HOLLIS

Ma'am? They're confirming you
now. The house says you're very
welcome—

ESTHER

(the window already
rising)

Please tell Mrs. Donohue thank
you for the invitation.

(beat)

And happy birthday to her
great-grandson.

The window closes. The Maybach reverses smoothly, swings
around, and pulls back out onto West Paces Ferry,
accelerating east into the dark.

Officer Hollis stands in the booth holding the invitation.

OFFICER HOLLIS

(into radio, baffled)

Belle Rive, Crown Gate. Scratch
that. The Smilley vehicle is...
departing.

Outside, Celeste watches the taillights disappear. She
turns to her cameraman.

CELESTE

Did you get that?

CAMERAMAN

Get what? I was white-balancing.

CELESTE

(staring after the car)

The only other woman in Atlanta
wearing red tonight just drove to
the Donohue gate and turned
around.

CAMERAMAN

So?

CELESTE

(slowly, fascinated)

So that's a story.

CUT TO:

24 INT. BELLE RIVE – THE GRAND BALLROOM – NIGHT

Wednesday, January 5, 2005 – 9:47 PM EST

Grace holds the last note of "Crown Me." The room EXPLODES in applause. Marc rushes the stage and lifts his sister off her feet, spinning her. The crowd cheers.

At the edge of the ballroom, Simone stands alone for a moment, applauding politely.

Winston appears at her elbow, the leather jewelry case under his arm. He leans in and speaks very quietly.

WINSTON

Madam. The Crown Gate radioed.

SIMONE

(still applauding)

Yes?

WINSTON

Miss Esther Smilley arrived at the gate four minutes ago. In red.

(beat)

And then she turned around.

Simone stops applauding. She's still for a long moment.

SIMONE

Did she say anything?

WINSTON

She asked the officer to thank you for the invitation.

(beat)

And to wish your great-grandson a happy birthday.

Simone looks across the ballroom at Marc, who is laughing with Grace in his arms, the happiest man in the world.

She holds out her hand. Winston gives her the leather case. She opens it. The black pearls gleam in the candlelight.

She looks at them for a long moment.

Then she closes the case with a soft click and hands it back to Winston.

SIMONE
Not tonight, then.

WINSTON
Madam?

SIMONE
(smiling a slow,
private smile)
She came to the gate twice in
three days, Winston. A girl who
does that isn't afraid of us.
(beat)
She's afraid of something inside
the house.

WINSTON
(carefully)
And what would that be, madam?

SIMONE
(looking at Marc)
I don't know yet.

She takes a glass of champagne from a passing tray.

SIMONE (CONT'D)
Next time, Winston. Keep them
close.

FADE OUT.

ACT SIX**25 INT. BELLE RIVE – THE GRAND BALLROOM – NIGHT**

Wednesday, January 5, 2005 – 9:58 PM EST

The band plays a fanfare. Waiters wheel in Nana Ruby's THREE-TIER POUND CAKE on its silver stand, lit with twenty-three candles. Nana Ruby walks beside it like an honor guard.

The crowd gathers. Marc stands before the cake with his family around him: Victor and Joan, Natasha and Robert, Grace, Elxa and Jeremy, Simone. Martin and Mallory are close by. Amond and Arianna are at the front of the crowd. Harmony is off to one side.

VICTOR

(raising a glass)

Before the boy blows out his
candles and eats that cake with
his hands, which he will...

Laughter.

VICTOR (CONT'D)

...his great-grandmother would
like to say a word.

The room quiets. Everyone knows what it means when Simone speaks.

Simone steps forward, straight-backed, in her dove-gray silk and white pearls. She takes a small object from her evening bag: an antique gold POCKET WATCH on a heavy chain, its case worn smooth by decades of a thumb.

She takes Marc's hand, turns it palm up, and presses the watch into it.

SIMONE

Your great-grandfather bought
this in 1936. The day the Hotel
Donohue opened. He paid for it
with the first week's receipts.

(beat)

He wound it every morning for
sixty-three years. The morning he
died, he wound it, and it was
still ticking at midnight when he
wasn't.

A hush over three hundred people.

SIMONE (CONT'D)
I've kept it in a drawer for five
years because I couldn't bear to
hear it.
(she closes his fingers
over it)
This was his. He'd want it
ticking.

Marc looks down at the watch in his hand. He opens the case. Inside the lid, a tiny engraving:

INSERT — ENGRAVING: "A. J. D. — 1936 — They closed every door."

MARC
(barely)
Gorgeous.

SIMONE
Don't cry in front of the Mayor,
Sunshine. She'll think we're
sentimental. She'll try to raise
our taxes.

Laughter through tears around the room. Marc laughs too, wiping his eyes. He kisses her forehead.

He winds the watch. Once, twice, three times. He holds it to his ear. It's ticking.

He holds it up to the room, grinning.

MARC
It works!

APPLAUSE.

MARC (CONT'D)
(to the room, voice
thick)
Okay. Okay. I'm supposed to make
a speech. I didn't write one,
because I'm a genius, and
geniuses don't write speeches,
they just ramble and people call
it vision.

Laughter.

MARC (CONT'D)

Thank you all for coming. Thank you, Mama and Daddy, for having me. It was a great idea. Ten out of ten.

(beat)

Nana Ruby, for the cake I'm about to destroy. Grace, for that song, which I will be crying about in my car for a week. Granddaddy, Grandma, Gorgeous...

He looks at his family. His voice drops.

MARC (CONT'D)

My great-grandfather used to say that he built a big house because they closed every door. And I've always thought the second half of that sentence was...

(beat)

Now you've got to fill it.

(beat)

So. Here's my birthday wish. Out loud, so it counts double.

He looks around the room, at the three hundred people who love him or want something from him, and at the few who are both.

MARC (CONT'D)

I wish for a table so big we can't see the end of it. And every chair full.

(he raises his glass)

To the empty chairs. May we fill them all.

ALL

To the empty chairs!

Amond, in the front row, raises his glass and meets Marc's eyes. He knows exactly which chair Marc means. They share the smallest look.

Marc blows out all twenty-three candles in one breath. Cheers. The band kicks into "September" by Earth, Wind & Fire. The room erupts into dancing.

Nana Ruby cuts the first slice and hands it to Marc on a china plate. He takes a huge bite with his hand, exactly as Victor predicted. Joan shakes her head. Simone laughs out loud.

LATER. The dance floor is packed. Near the mirrored pedestal, a slim woman in a black hoodie and jeans, completely out of place among the gowns, stands alone staring up at the ICE SCULPTURE.

KEISHA "GHOST" LATTIMORE.

A WAITER approaches her, alarmed at the hoodie.

WAITER
Ma'am, this is a black-tie—

KEISHA
(not looking away from
the duck)
I'm with security.

He retreats. Keisha studies the crowned swan for a long, solemn moment.

Across the ballroom, Marc spots her. He lights up and raises his cake plate to her in salute.

Keisha looks at him. She looks at the duck. Then she gives Marc a small, grave thumbs-up, takes a slice of pound cake from a passing tray, and walks out the service door without a word.

Marc laughs so hard he has to put his plate down.

CUT TO:

26 EXT. BELLE RIVE — THE LOWER GARDEN — NIGHT
Wednesday, January 5, 2005 — 10:33 PM EST

A formal garden stepping down toward the river: boxwood hedges and a marble fountain turned off for winter, lit by lanterns. The party sounds distant up the hill.

Marc sits on the edge of the dry fountain with his jacket off, the pocket watch in one hand and a second slice of cake in the other. His RAZR is at his ear.

MARC
(into phone, low)
Did he eat it?

INTERCUT WITH:

INT. DEE'S KITCHEN — BACK OFFICE — SAME TIME

Mama Dee sits in her cramped office with her shoes off and her feet on a milk crate, the rotary phone at her ear.

MAMA DEE

Two slices. With a fork he keeps in his pocket. That man's been carrying his own silverware since 1964.

MARC

And?

MAMA DEE

And he gave us Friday. Friday night. The funeral's Saturday morning at Greater Cascade. Four hundred people. He says if he doesn't have an answer by then, he'll give them one.

(beat)

And baby, he asked me something.

MARC

What?

MAMA DEE

He asked who in this city wants him and us in a war.

(beat)

I didn't have an answer. I don't like not having answers.

Marc looks up the hill at the glowing palazzo: three hundred guests, his whole family, his cousin somewhere inside with a Machiavelli.

MARC

(quietly)

Neither do I.

MAMA DEE

(softening)

Now go eat your birthday cake and quit working. Happy birthday, sugar.

MARC

Thank you, Mama Dee.

END INTERCUT.

He closes the phone. He winds the pocket watch again out of habit and listens to it tick.

Elxa comes down the stone steps in her black gown, holding her shoes in one hand.

ELXA
You're hiding.

MARC
I'm digesting. There's a difference.

She sits beside him. He offers her the cake. She takes a bite without comment.

ELXA
Nice speech.

MARC
I rambled.

ELXA
It was nice rambling.

A beat. The fountain is dry. The party thumps faintly above them.

ELXA (CONT'D)
The Mayor was in Daddy's study with Granddaddy tonight. Alone.

MARC
(carefully)
Okay?

ELXA
She touched his arm. He toasted her.

MARC
Elx, the Mayor touches everybody's arm. It's a campaign reflex. She touched a valet's arm on the way in. I saw it.

ELXA
(beat)
Maybe.

MARC
It's a party. Politicians go to parties. That's their whole job.

ELXA
(not convinced)
Maybe.

Marc looks at his sister. He sees how tired she is. He makes a decision.

MARC
Hey. Can I tell you something?
Totally random?

ELXA
You're going to anyway.

MARC
If I were Chief of Police, and I wanted to know who in my house talks to Channel 8, I'd pull the personal cell phone records of everybody on my command staff for Monday night. Around ten o'clock.
(beat)
Not the department phones. The personal ones.

Elxa turns and stares at him.

ELXA
Why would you say that?

MARC
(shrugging, eating cake)
Because that's what I'd do. At BSI. If I had a leak.

ELXA
Marc. Do you KNOW something?

MARC
I know Celeste had the coin forty minutes before anybody. And I know she says "he."
(beat)
That's all I know. Birthday magic.

ELXA
(slowly)
She told you her source was a "he"?

MARC
She talks in her sleep.

ELXA
(despite herself)
Gross.

MARC
I'm just saying. Personal phones.
Ten o'clock.

Elxa looks at him for a long time: at the frosting on his thumb and the pocket watch in his hand, at her baby brother, who is smarter than everyone and pretends not to be.

ELXA
(quietly)
You know what scares me about you?

MARC
My hairline?

ELXA
(not smiling)
That you're always right. And you never tell me how.

She stands, picks up her shoes, and walks back up toward the house.

ELXA (CONT'D)
(without turning)
Happy birthday, Marc.

MARC
(watching her go)
Love you, Chief.

She doesn't answer. But on the steps, where he can't see, she smiles.

CUT TO:

27 INT. VICTOR'S ROLLS-ROYCE — MOVING — SOVEREIGN WAY — NIGHT

Wednesday, January 5, 2005 — 10:51 PM EST

The quarter-mile drive from Belle Rive to Donohue Manor. The gas lamps of Sovereign Way slide past the windows. Winston drives, eyes forward.

In the back seat, Victor and Joan sit side by side. Simone rode home earlier. Joan looks out her window. She hasn't spoken since the car door closed.

VICTOR
It was a lovely party.

JOAN
It was.

VICTOR
The boy cried at the watch.

JOAN
He did.

VICTOR
My mother was magnificent.

JOAN
She always is.

Silence. The lamps slide by.

JOAN (CONT'D)
(still looking out the
window)
You toasted her.

VICTOR
My mother?

JOAN
The Mayor. In Robert's study.
With the door almost closed.
(beat)
Our granddaughter saw you,
Victor. She came back to the
ballroom white as a sheet and ate
a plate of shrimp standing up.
Elxa never eats standing up.

Victor says nothing for a moment.

VICTOR
Jo Whitaker thanked me for a
donation to the library fund.

JOAN
(turning to him at
last)
Victor Donohue. I sat on the
federal bench for twenty-four

years. I have heard every lie a man can tell with his hands folded. You are not even good at it. You are just rich enough that nobody's ever told you so.

Winston's eyes flick to the rearview mirror, then firmly back to the road.

VICTOR
(quietly)
What do you want me to say, Joan?

JOAN
The truth.

VICTOR
(beat)
The truth is that our granddaughter is going to be a great Chief of Police. And nothing I did or didn't do changes that.

JOAN
(very quiet)
It changes everything if she ever finds out.

The Rolls pulls up to the Manor steps. Winston gets out and opens Joan's door. She steps out without taking Victor's hand.

She walks up the steps alone. Victor sits in the back seat, watching her go.

WINSTON
(at the open door,
carefully)
Sir?

VICTOR
(not moving)
Give me a minute, Winston.

WINSTON
Yes, sir.

He closes the door gently. Victor sits alone in the dark car.

CUT TO:

**28 INT. ELXA'S UNMARKED CROWN VICTORIA — MOVING — WEST
PACES FERRY ROAD — NIGHT**

Wednesday, January 5, 2005 — 11:07 PM EST

Elxa drives. Jeremy is in the passenger seat with his bow tie undone and a foil-wrapped slice of pound cake in his lap from Nana Ruby.

They pass the WBKG van packing up outside the Crown Gate. Neither comments.

ELXA

I need the personal cell phone records for my entire command staff. Monday night.

JEREMY

(turning)

Personal?

ELXA

Personal.

JEREMY

Babe, that's a subpoena. For your own deputies. On their private phones. With no crime alleged except talking to a reporter.

ELXA

Leaking evidence in an active homicide is a crime.

JEREMY

It's a policy violation. It's only a crime if you can prove it compromised the case, and you'd need to show that to a judge.

(beat)

You'd need the DA to sign off on it.

ELXA

Then I'll ask the DA.

JEREMY

Arianna.

ELXA

Arianna.

JEREMY

(carefully)

And what do you tell her when she asks why you suspect your own command staff?

Elxa drives in silence for a moment.

ELXA
I'll tell her my instincts.

JEREMY
Your instincts, or your brother?

She glances at him sharply.

JEREMY (CONT'D)
I saw you two in the garden. You came back up the steps with the face you make when you've just been told something you can't un-know.

ELXA
(beat)
He said Celeste told him her source was a "he."

JEREMY
Marc said.

ELXA
Marc said.

JEREMY
(slowly)
And how does Marc know which phone records to pull?

Elxa doesn't answer. She drives. The headlights sweep over the bare trees.

ELXA
(finally)
He said, "Birthday magic."

JEREMY
(unwrapping the pound cake)
Your brother's got a lot of magic, Elxa.

He takes a bite. She glances at him.

ELXA

Don't.

JEREMY

I didn't say anything.

ELXA

You said "magic" like it was evidence.

JEREMY

(mouth full)

I'm a detective. Everything's evidence.

She almost laughs. She doesn't. She drives on into the dark.

CUT TO:

29 INT. RAVENHURST – THE MOTOR COURT – SMILLEY MAYBACH – NIGHT

Wednesday, January 5, 2005 – 10:44 PM EST

The Maybach sits parked and idling in the dark motor court of the château. It's been there a while. The driver and Crowe stand outside by the fountain, not looking at the car.

Inside, in the back seat, alone in the red dress, sits Esther. She has taken off the diamond. It sits in her palm.

She takes a small photo from her evening bag: the twins at their second birthday, in matching white dresses. Emma serious. Victoria mid-laugh, her head thrown back.

She looks at it for a long time.

ESTHER

(barely a whisper)

He laughs like her.

She presses the photo against her chest and closes her eyes.

Then she opens her RAZR and types.

INSERT – TEXT TO "HARM": "Didn't go. Tell me everything tomorrow. Every single thing."

She sends it. Almost instantly, a reply:

INSERT — TEXT FROM "HARM": "Girl you MISSED IT. His great-grandma gave him a watch and everybody cried. Also the duck is real. Call you after DA tomorrow. 10am!! Pray for me."

Esther reads it. "Everybody cried." She closes the phone.

She sits in the dark car, a woman in a red dress who drove to a gate and couldn't go through it.

Then she opens the door and walks inside. She's back before eleven, as promised.

CUT TO:

30 INT. THE BULLOCK PAVILION — LIVING ROOM — NIGHT
Wednesday, January 5, 2005 — 11:38 PM EST

Marc's glass house over the river. The party is over. Marc, tie undone, has set Simone's pocket watch on the coffee table where he can hear it tick. Martin's book sits beside it, still in its black paper.

Celeste comes in, still in the red gown with the WBKG parka over it, her feet bare, her heels in her hand. She's buzzing.

CELESTE

You didn't watch my live shot.

MARC

I was eating my third piece of cake.

CELESTE

I stood in front of your family's gate in twenty-eight-degree weather for three minutes, looking amazing, for you.

MARC

For your ratings.

CELESTE

For both.
(dropping onto the sofa
beside him)
But that's not the good part.

MARC

There's a good part?

CELESTE
(leaning in, eyes
bright)
At nine-forty tonight, a black
Maybach pulled up to your Crown
Gate. And in the back seat, in a
floor-length red Valentino—
(beat, outraged)
—my DRESS, Marc, my COLOR—
(beat)
—was Esther Smilley.

Marc goes completely still.

MARC
Here?

CELESTE
At the gate. She handed the guard
the invitation. And then she
looked at something in the
guardhouse, and she just...
turned around. Drove away. Like
she'd seen a ghost.

Marc doesn't say anything.

CELESTE (CONT'D)
The Smilley heiress. At your
birthday. In MY color. And then
she runs away.
(delighted)
That's a story, baby.

MARC
(quietly)
Don't run it.

CELESTE
What?

MARC
(turning to her)
Please. Don't run it. It's my
birthday. Let me have one thing
that isn't on Channel 8.

Celeste looks at him, surprised by his seriousness. Then
she softens.

CELESTE
(beat)
Fine. Birthday present.

(kissing him)
But Bernadette Sinclair is going
to find out and I'm going to be
furious.

She stands and heads for the bedroom, dropping her parka
as she goes.

CELESTE (CONT'D)
Coming?

MARC
In a minute.

She disappears. Marc sits alone.

He pulls a laptop from under the coffee table and opens
it. He logs into the BSI security system: CROWN GATE –
CAMERA 2 – 01/05/05.

He scrubs the footage back to 21:41.

The gate floodlights. The black Maybach. The rear window
lowers.

He freezes the frame.

On the screen, in high-resolution color: ESTHER SMILLEY,
in scarlet, one diamond at her throat, leaning toward the
guardhouse. Her eyes are fixed on something inside the
booth. Her face is caught in the exact instant before she
pulls away: stricken, frightened, and beautiful.

Marc looks at her face on the screen for a long time.

On the coffee table, Alexander's pocket watch TICKS.

He reaches into his breast pocket and pulls out a folded
piece of paper: Tuesday's gate log. "SMILLEY 1 – IDLED 58
SECONDS."

He sets the log beside the laptop and looks from one to
the other.

MARC
(to the frozen face on
the screen, softly)
Esther Smilley.
(beat)
Why do you keep coming to my
gate?

The watch ticks. The river runs black below the glass.

HOLD on her frozen face.

FADE OUT.

END OF EPISODE #0003

NEXT ON BEYOND THE KINGDOM...

- In the District Attorney's office, HARMONY slides a yellow flyer across the desk: "Please. Everybody else stopped looking." ARIANNA, very still: "I won't stop."
- In the Dowager House, GRACE and MALLORY lay out a hundred glass sample jars in front of SIMONE, who picks one up and sniffs it. SIMONE: "My formulas are seventy years old. What makes you think you deserve them?"
- SIMONE, to the two girls: "One condition." (beat) "Beat the Smilleys."
- At Merriweather & Sons, SILAS checks his watch: "Two days, Dolores."

FADE TO BLACK.